

The opium of the people



When Kant proposed that the noumenal world is beyond our apprehension (see [Phenomenon and noumenon](#)), he showed that there could be no proof either way for the existence or non-existence of God. Hegel pointed out our alienation from God, and Feuerbach argued that God was a human creation: the separation of religion from philosophy was almost complete. Marx, who as both a materialist and an atheist argued that theology should be replaced with reason, saw religion as an example of how a class can be made to hold beliefs contrary to their own interests. His famous definition of religion as the ‘opium of the people’ interpreted it as an attempt to find an illusory

happiness in the face of oppression and alienation, and called for its abolition, by removing conditions that require illusions and replacing them with those that bring true happiness. This was in line both with Marx's rationalist approach to philosophy and history, and also with the emergence of new disciplines, such as economics, sociology and psychology, from their philosophical roots using scientific methodology.